

China: SAFE data suggest some FX inflows in April

Bottom line:

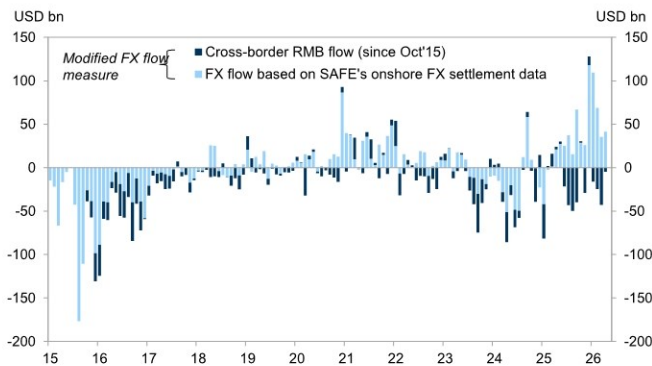
Our preferred FX flow measure shows net FX inflows of US\$37bn in April 2026 (vs. US\$7bn outflows in March). The current account channel showed US\$34bn FX inflows in April, and the portfolio investment channel saw some FX inflows from both FX settlement data (only covering flows denominated in FX) and net foreign receipts (covering flows denominated in both FX and RMB). Official FX reserves rose by US\$46bn after being adjusted for FX valuation effects, and commercial banks' external assets increased by US\$19bn from March to April.

Main points:

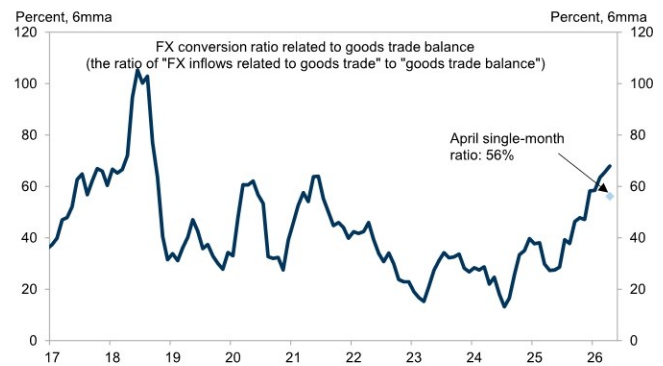
1. In April, we saw US\$33bn net inflows via onshore outright spot transactions, and US\$9bn inflows via freshly entered and canceled forward transactions. Another SAFE dataset on "cross-border RMB flows" showed outflows of US\$5bn in the month. Our preferred FX flow measure therefore suggests US\$37bn net FX inflows in April, in comparison with US\$7bn FX outflows in March ([Exhibit 1](#)).
2. The current account channel showed net inflows (US\$34bn in April vs. US\$47bn inflows in March). We saw a net inflow of US\$48bn related to goods trade in April, down from a net inflow of US\$60bn in March. The April FX conversion ratio fell to 56% (vs. 117% in March and 74% in Q1; [Exhibit 2](#)). The FX outflows related to the services trade deficit declined to US\$12bn in April (vs. a US\$14bn outflows in March). The income and transfers account showed a US\$2bn outflow in April (vs. a US\$1bn inflow in March).
3. The portfolio investment channel saw US\$12bn FX inflows in April (vs. US\$7bn outflows in March). North-Bound Bond Connect flows showed US\$10bn outflows vs. US\$19bn outflows in March ([Exhibit 3](#)). As a broader proxy for capital flows, net foreign receipts related to portfolio investment indicated inflows in April (US\$14bn inflows vs. US\$53bn outflows in March).¹
4. Official FX reserves (released earlier in the month) rose to US\$3,411bn in April from US\$3,342bn in March. By our estimate, FX valuation effects would have raised FX reserves by US\$23bn in April, so after adjusting for FX valuation effects, FX reserves increased by US\$46bn. In addition, we note that commercial banks' net external assets increased by US\$19bn in April (vs. a US\$10bn decrease in March; [Exhibit 4](#)). The outstanding amount of banks' net external assets now stands at

¹ Net FX receipts closely track the BOP portfolio investment balance, covering both inbound and outbound portfolio investment, denominated in either foreign currency or Renminbi. In contrast, FX net settlement only covers those flows denominated in foreign currency.

US\$1,491bn.

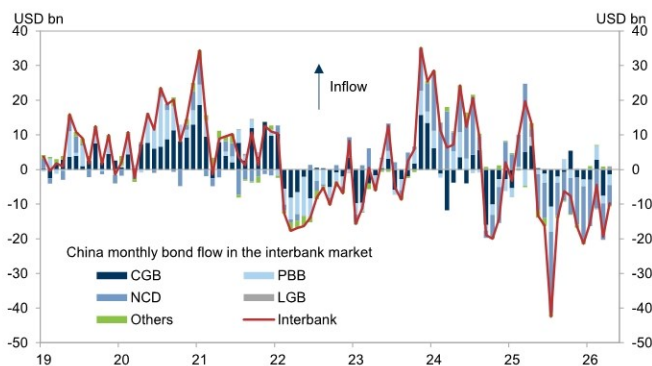
Xinquan Chen**Exhibit 1: Our preferred gauge suggests some FX inflows in April**

Source: SAFE, Data compiled by Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 2: FX conversion ratio for goods trade balance fell from March to April

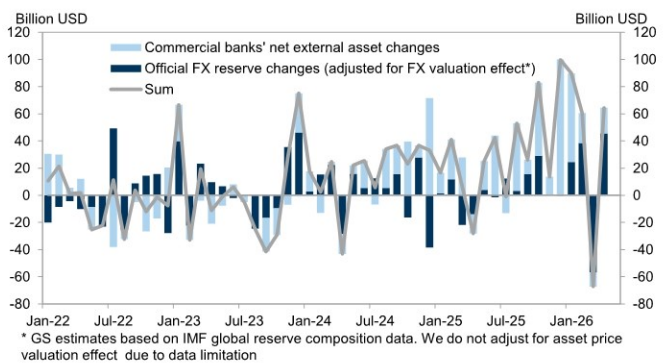
The line shows a six-month moving average of FX conversion ratio.

Source: CEIC, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 3: Foreign investors continued to sell CNY bonds in April

CGB: Central government bonds, LGB: Local government bonds, PBB: Policy bank bonds, NCD: Negotiable certificate of deposits

Source: CEIC, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 4: Banks' net external assets increased in April, and official FX reserves rose after adjusting for FX valuation effect

* GS estimates based on IMF global reserve composition data. We do not adjust for asset price valuation effect due to data limitation

Source: PBOC, CEIC, Data compiled by Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

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